

Leading Kazhdan–Lusztig coefficients with fully commutative lower endpoints in type E^*

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October 2026

Abstract

We prove that the Kazhdan–Lusztig coefficient $\mu(x, w)$ lies in $\{0, 1\}$ whenever x is fully commutative and w is arbitrary in a Weyl group of type E_6 , E_7 or E_8 . Together with the known results in types A and D , this settles Green’s 0–1 question for every finite simply laced Coxeter group. The proof uses star operations to reduce to terminal (T -avoiding) upper endpoints, which we classify by exhaustive enumeration with parabolic pruning. Apart from the type- D elements classified by Gern and their parabolic embeddings, there are just two new terminals, of lengths 28 and 50. Fan’s monomial cell theory forces a unique eligible fully commutative lower endpoint for each terminal, and parity eliminates every new case. We also construct infinite families of full-support terminals in E_8 , E_{10} and every generalized type E_{4r+1} , $r \geq 3$, for which $\mu(x, w) = 0$ for all fully commutative x . These family arguments are symbolic in their parameters, with finite computational inputs specified separately.

MSC 2020: 20F55 (primary), 20C08, 05E10. Keywords: Kazhdan–Lusztig polynomials, fully commutative elements, Coxeter groups of type E , T -avoiding elements.

1 Introduction

Let (W, S) be a Coxeter system with length function ℓ and Bruhat order $\leq$, and let $P_{x,w}(q)$ be its ordinary equal-parameter Kazhdan–Lusztig polynomials [17]. Put $\mu(x, w) = [q^{(\ell(w)-\ell(x)-1)/2}]P_{x,w}(q)$ if $x < w$ and $\ell(w) - \ell(x)$ is odd, and $\mu(x, w) = 0$ otherwise. Thus μ is the coefficient at the largest allowed degree when the gap is odd; it need not be the leading nonzero coefficient of $P_{x,w}$. A *cover* is a pair $x < w$ with $\ell(w) - \ell(x) = 1$; then $P_{x,w} = 1$ and $\mu(x, w) = 1$. Write $L(w) = \{s \in S : \ell(sw) < \ell(w)\}$ and $R(w) = \{s \in S : \ell(ws) < \ell(w)\}$ for the descent sets and $\text{supp}(w)$ for the set of generators in a reduced word of w ; w has *full support* if $\text{supp}(w) = S$. Following Stembridge [21], w is *fully commutative* (FC) if any two of its reduced words are related by interchanging adjacent commuting generators; in a simply laced system this holds if and only if no reduced word of w contains a factor sts with $m(s, t) = 3$ [21, Proposition 2.1]. The FC elements form the set W_{FC} . A set $I \subseteq S$ of pairwise commuting generators is an *independent set* of the Coxeter graph; $i(I) = \prod_{s \in I} s$ is a *commuting product*. An element is *terminal* if no reduced word for it begins or ends with two noncommuting generators, and a *noncommuting terminal* if moreover it is not a commuting product; these are Gern’s weakly bad and bad elements [9, Definition 2.1.1] and Laird’s T -avoiding and T_2 -avoiding elements [18, §2.2].

Theorem 1.1 (Finite exceptional types). *If W has type E_6 , E_7 or E_8 , then $\mu(x, w) \in \{0, 1\}$ for all $x \in W_{\text{FC}}$ and $w \in W$.*

Corollary 1.2 (Finite simply laced groups). *If W is a finite simply laced Coxeter group, $x \in W_{\text{FC}}$ and $w \in W$, then $\mu(x, w) \in \{0, 1\}$.*

Our second theme is arbitrarily large rank. Throughout, the generalized diagram E_n , $n \geq 6$, is the chain $0-1-\dots-(n-2)$ with node $n-1$ attached to node 2; thus $E_9 = \tilde{E}_8$, and E_n is indefinite for $n \geq 10$. Section 4.2 defines, for every $r \geq 3$, explicit real roots $\beta_{r,k}$ ($k \geq 0$) of E_{4r+1} , with reflections $b_{r,k} = r_{\beta_{r,k}}$, and an independent set I_r of size $2r+1$.

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Theorem 1.3 (A rank-uniform family). *For every $r \geq 3$ the reflections $b_{r,k}$, $k \geq 0$, are pairwise distinct full-support terminal elements of $W(E_{4r+1})$ that are not fully commutative, with $L(b_{r,k}) = R(b_{r,k}) = I_r$. For every fully commutative x and every $k \geq 0$, $\mu(x, b_{r,k}) = 0$.*

Theorem 4.7 gives an analogous family in $\tilde{E}_8$ with exact lengths $27 + 92k$, and Proposition 4.8 one in E_{10} ; so the terminal obstructions to length-decreasing star reduction cannot be exhausted by a finite list in E_n for $n \geq 9$.

Green [13, Introduction] asked whether $\mu(x, w) \in \{0, 1\}$ for fully commutative x in a large class of Coxeter groups, “possibly all of them”; Chmutov [3, abstract and §2.3] calls this *Green’s 0–1 conjecture*. It is known in types A and $\tilde{A}$ (Green [13, Theorem 4.1; Theorem 3.1 of the arXiv version]), $B = C$ (Chmutov [3, Theorem 2.3.8]) and D (Gern [9, Theorem 4.5.11]). Theorem 1.1 completes the finite simply laced case. The finite irreducible types not covered by these results are F_4 , H_3 and H_4 ; dihedral groups, including G_2 , have $P_{x,w} = 1$ for $x \leq w$ [19, Proposition 7.3]. Finiteness cannot be dropped from Corollary 1.2: $\mu = 2$ occurs in $\tilde{D}_4$. The FC hypothesis is also essential, since $\mu = 10$ occurs in E_6 with a non-FC lower endpoint (Section 5).

Jones [16, Theorems 1.2 and 6.1] proved the bound for a Deodhar upper endpoint in every finite Weyl group (E_6 , E_7 , E_8 , F_4 and G_2 by computer). This uses a hypothesis on the upper endpoint. When both endpoints are fully commutative the bound holds in every E_n by Graham’s thesis [10], as reported in Green [12, Remark 9.5].

The reduction to terminal upper endpoints (Lemma 2.2) is Green’s argument as adapted by Gern, and the lower-endpoint lemma (Lemma 2.4) is Fan’s monomial cell theorem [5] in Green’s formulation [12]; what is new is the classification of the terminal elements of E_6 , E_7 and E_8 (Proposition 3.1) by exhaustive enumeration, with parabolic pruning in place of the 696,729,600 elements of E_8 . The noncommuting terminals turn out to be Gern’s type- D list together with exactly two new elements, $w_7^E \in E_7$ of length 28 and $w_8^E \in E_8$ of length 50 (Remark 3.4); each has a unique fully commutative lower endpoint satisfying both descent inclusions, with even length gap for the new ones, so the only Kazhdan–Lusztig value needed is Gern’s D_6 value $\mu(x_6, w_6) = 1$ [9, Lemma 4.5.5] (du Cloux’s Coxeter; recomputed in Appendix A).

Here is the route through the finite proof. For a non-cover pair, a nonzero $\mu(x, w)$ forces both descent sets of w into those of x . Star operations decrease the upper endpoint’s length until either a cover is reached or the upper endpoint is terminal. For each terminal in the finite list, the common descent set is a maximum independent set on its support. This forces x to be the product of those descents, leaving a single coefficient to consider. Its length gap is even except for the inherited D_6 pair. Covers have $\mu = 1$ from the outset.

The infinite families use the same maximum-descent principle, but a vanishing statement also requires excluding FC covers. For reflections, Lemma 4.2 does this by the lifting property and a braid in a reduced palindromic word. The affine family instead uses a finite FC catalogue and a base-cover check. Appendix A separates these proof inputs from the additional computational checks.

Infinite families of T -avoiding elements inside a fixed infinite Coxeter group were known in affine type A with an even number of generators (Fan–Green [6, Proposition 3.1.2], fully commutative), and in affine type C (the sandwich stacks of Laird [18, §2.3, Figures 2.8–2.9], within Ernst’s type-II non-cancellable elements [4, §3.2]). For type F_n , Laird [18, §3.3] reports unpublished non-FC constructions of Cross, Ernst, Hills–Kimball and Quaranta (2012) and Gilbertson–Ernst (2013). Laird’s 2016 list of open classification problems includes affine type E [18, §5.3]. By Green’s theorem [11, Theorem 6.3] every E_n is star reducible, so every fully commutative terminal in E_n is a commuting product, which is why all families here are non-FC.

Related computational work includes Geck’s *PyCox* [7] and Geck–Halls’s analysis of the cells of E_8 [8]. Cell partitions alone do not settle the bound here: the FC elements are not a union of Kazhdan–Lusztig left cells in type E [14, Example 2.2.5]. Green–Losonczy attribute this phenomenon to Graham’s thesis [10, §9.9]. Moreover, the off-diagonal action in a left-cell W -graph only uses a coefficient $\tilde{\mu}(x, w)$ when some generator belongs to $L(x) \setminus L(w)$ [8, Remark 2.1]; equal-descent pairs, such as our residual terminal pairs, are invisible to this action. To our knowledge, the exceptional bound, the terminal lists of Table 1 and the infinite families have not appeared before.

Sections 2, 3 and 4 contain the structural lemmas, the finite theorem and the infinite families, Section 5 complements and open problems, and Appendix A the computational certificates.

2 Structural reductions

2.1 Star reduction

We use the elementary properties of μ from [17, §2.3 and Theorem 4.2], restated in [9, Proposition 1.2.4].

Lemma 2.1 (Descent criterion). *Let $x < w$. If $s \in L(w) \setminus L(x)$, then $\mu(x, w) = 0$ unless $x = sw$; if $s \in R(w) \setminus R(x)$, then $\mu(x, w) = 0$ unless $x = ws$.*

Proof. This is [17, (2.3.e) and (2.3.f)]; see [9, Proposition 1.2.4(3),(4)]. $\square$

For noncommuting generators s, t with $m(s, t) = 3$ let $D_L(s, t) = \{w : |L(w) \cap \{s, t\}| = 1\}$. For $w \in D_L(s, t)$ exactly one of sw, tw lies in $D_L(s, t)$; it is the left star $*w$. Right stars w^* are defined symmetrically. Stars preserve full commutativity in simply laced systems [11, Introduction]; see also [9, Proposition 1.1.29]. Star transport [17, Theorem 4.2], also stated in [9, Proposition 1.2.4(1),(2)], says that for $x, w \in D_L(s, t)$,

$$\tilde{\mu}(x, w) = \tilde{\mu}(*x, *w), \quad (1)$$

where $\tilde{\mu}(y, z)$ equals $\mu(y, z)$ if $y < z$, $\mu(z, y)$ if $z < y$, and 0 otherwise; the same holds for right stars.

Lemma 2.2 (Terminal reduction). *Let W be simply laced. If $\mu(x, b) \in \{0, 1\}$ for every terminal upper endpoint b and every fully commutative x , then $\mu(x, w) \in \{0, 1\}$ for all $x \in W_{\text{FC}}$ and all $w \in W$.*

Proof. This is the argument of Green [13, proof of Theorem 3.1 (published Theorem 4.1)], as adapted by Gern [9, Lemma 2.3.10 and Theorem 4.5.11]. We induct on $\ell(w)$. Put $d = \ell(w) - \ell(x)$; only $x < w$ with $d \geq 3$ odd needs proof. If $L(w) \not\subseteq L(x)$ or $R(w) \not\subseteq R(x)$, Lemma 2.1 gives zero; so assume both inclusions, whence $L(w)$ and $R(w)$ are commuting, like the descent sets of the fully commutative x . If w is terminal, the hypothesis applies. Otherwise let $w = stv$ be reduced with $m(s, t) = 3$ (a noncommuting suffix is treated with right stars). Then $s \in L(w)$, $t \notin L(w)$ because $L(w)$ is commuting, and $s, t \notin L(v)$ (t by reducedness, and $s \in L(v)$ would give $w = stsv' = tstv'$ and $t \in L(w)$); so $\{tv, stv\}$ is the left $\{s, t\}$ -string in $D_L(s, t)$ and $*w = sw$ has length $\ell(w) - 1$. Descent inclusion gives $s \in L(x)$ and full commutativity $t \notin L(x)$, so $x \in D_L(s, t)$ and $*x$ is defined and fully commutative. By (1), $\mu(x, w) = \tilde{\mu}(*x, *w)$; as $\ell(*x) = \ell(x) \pm 1$, the new length difference is d or $d - 2$, both positive, so the value is zero if the new endpoints are incomparable and lies in $\{0, 1\}$ by induction otherwise. $\square$

Remark 2.3 (A star step that reaches a cover). On the path 0–1–2, take

$$x = s_1, \quad w = s_1 s_0 s_2 s_1.$$

These words are reduced, with lengths 1 and 4, and $x < w$ by the subword property [2, Theorem 2.2.2]. Both left descent sets equal $\{s_1\}$, so both elements lie in $D_L(s_1, s_0)$. Their left stars are

$$*x = s_0 s_1, \quad *w = s_0 s_2 s_1.$$

The upper length decreases by one and the lower length increases by one: the gap drops from 3 to 1. Deleting s_2 from the displayed reduced word for $*w$ gives $*x$, so the new pair is a cover. Star transport therefore gives $\mu(x, w) = \mu(*x, *w) = 1$. This also exhibits the exception in Lemma 2.1: $s_2 \in L(*w) \setminus L(*x)$, but $*x = s_2 *w$. The reduction can thus finish at a cover before reaching a terminal.

2.2 Maximum commuting descents

The next lemma is the point where the size of the descent set controls the entire lower endpoint. Its type- D predecessor is [9, Lemma 4.5.8]. We use Fan’s monomial cell theory for the Temperley–Lieb quotient [5], in the formulation of Green [12, §4]; statement numbers refer to arXiv:0704.0283v1.

Write b_y , $y \in W_{\text{FC}}$, for the monomial basis of this quotient. Two elements lie in the same monomial right cell if each of their basis elements can be obtained from the other by right multiplication by monomial basis elements, up to a nonzero scalar. Left cells are defined using left multiplication. These are cells of the quotient’s monomial basis; we do not identify them with ordinary Kazhdan–Lusztig cells. Define

$$a_{\text{TL}}(y) = \max\{|A| : y = u i(A) v \text{ length-additively, } A \text{ independent}\}.$$

This is Fan’s a -function [5, Definition 2.3.1, p. 141], as in [12, Definition 4.1]. We need two facts:

1. The monomial right cell of $i(A)$ consists exactly of the FC elements $y = i(A)v$ with length additive and $a_{\text{TL}}(y) = |A|$. The analogous statement for left cells uses a suffix $i(A)$ [12, Proposition 4.4(iv)], [5, Proposition 4.4.3 and its dual, p. 148].
2. A monomial left cell and a monomial right cell in the same two-sided cell intersect in exactly one element [12, Proposition 4.4(v)], [5, p. 140 and proof of Theorem 6.1.2, p. 154].

These facts hold throughout the series E_n , $n \geq 6$, including the affine and indefinite cases.

Lemma 2.4 (Maximum common commuting descents). *Let $n \geq 6$, $W = W(E_n)$, and let $x \in W_{\text{FC}}$ with $\text{supp}(x) \subseteq K$. Let I be an independent set of maximum cardinality in the subgraph induced by K . If $I \subseteq L(x) \cap R(x)$, then $x = i(I)$.*

Proof. Because the generators in I commute and are left descents, $i(I)$ is a reduced prefix of x . The right descent inclusion makes it a reduced suffix as well; these need not be disjoint occurrences. The prefix gives $a_{\text{TL}}(x) \geq |I|$. Conversely, every commuting factor in a reduced expression for x uses an independent subset of K , so the maximum cardinality assumption gives $a_{\text{TL}}(x) \leq |I|$.

Thus $a_{\text{TL}}(x) = |I|$. Fact (1) puts x in both the monomial right cell and the monomial left cell of $i(I)$. Their intersection already contains $i(I)$, and Fact (2) says that it contains only one element. Therefore $x = i(I)$. This is the singleton-cell argument used at the end of [12, proof of Lemma 5.2]. $\square$

The word *maximum* is essential. On a three-node path 0–1–2, the set $\{1\}$ is maximal under inclusion, but the independent set $\{0, 2\}$ is larger. The FC element $s_1 s_0 s_2 s_1$ has both descent sets equal to $\{s_1\}$ and is not s_1 . Thus maximality alone would not give the upper bound on $a_{\text{TL}}(x)$.

Proposition 2.5 (Maximum-descent parity criterion). *Let $n \geq 6$ and let $b \in W(E_n)$ satisfy $L(b) = R(b) = I$, where I is a maximum independent set in the subgraph induced by $\text{supp}(b)$. If $\ell(b) \equiv |I| \pmod{2}$, then for every $x \in W_{\text{FC}}$,*

$$\mu(x, b) \in \{0, 1\}, \quad x < b, \ell(b) - \ell(x) > 1 \implies \mu(x, b) = 0.$$

Proof. The type- D prototype is [9, Lemmas 4.5.4 and 4.5.9]. Let $x < b$ be fully commutative with $\ell(b) - \ell(x) > 1$ and $\mu(x, b) \neq 0$. By Lemma 2.1, $I \subseteq L(x) \cap R(x)$; the subword property gives $\text{supp}(x) \subseteq \text{supp}(b)$, so Lemma 2.4 with $K = \text{supp}(b)$ forces $x = i(I)$. Then $\ell(b) - \ell(x) = \ell(b) - |I|$ is even and $\mu(x, b) = 0$, a contradiction. Covers have $\mu = 1$. $\square$

Remark 2.6. Proposition 2.5 does not require b to be terminal. The parity hypothesis cannot be dropped: Section 5.3 exhibits elements of $\tilde{E}_8$ satisfying every other hypothesis with $\mu(i(I), b) = 1$.

Remark 2.7. The independence number of E_n is $\lceil n/2 \rceil$: excluding node 2 leaves three paths with maximum total $2 + \lceil (n-4)/2 \rceil$, and including it gives $2 + \lceil (n-5)/2 \rceil$, the larger of the two being $\lceil n/2 \rceil$.

2.3 Geometric terminal test

Normalize simple roots by $(\alpha_j, \alpha_j) = 2$ and $(\alpha_s, \alpha_t) = -1$ for adjacent nodes, and write $s \sim t$ when s and t are adjacent, i.e. $m(s, t) = 3$. For a real root β the reflection r_β acts by $r_\beta(\rho) = \rho - (\rho, \beta)\beta$; W acts on the left and the matrix of w has columns $w(\alpha_j)$. Root inequalities refer to the simple-root basis, and $s \in R(w)$ if and only if $w(\alpha_s) < 0$ [2, Proposition 4.4.6]. Since $(ws)(\alpha_t) = w(\alpha_s + \alpha_t)$ for $s \sim t$, the right-terminal test is

$$s \in R(w) \implies w(\alpha_s + \alpha_t) > 0 \quad \text{for every } t \sim s, \tag{2}$$

and testing w^{-1} gives the left-terminal condition.

3 Finite exceptional types

3.1 The terminal classification

A fully commutative x is *eligible* for a terminal b if $x \leq b$, $L(b) \subseteq L(x)$ and $R(b) \subseteq R(x)$; by Lemma 2.1, every ineligible non-cover has $\mu(x, b) = 0$. Elements are written as strings of node labels in the numbering of

Section 1: the chain $0-1-\dots-(n-2)$ with node $n-1$ attached to node 2.¹ A string denotes the product of the corresponding simple reflections in the order written, with the left action and column convention of Section 2.3. Every element displayed in Table 1 and in the affine family of Section 4.3 is an involution, so a string and its reverse denote the same element.

Proposition 3.1 (Computational classification). *The noncommuting terminals in E_6 , E_7 and E_8 are exactly the eleven elements in Table 1. Both descent sets of each of them equal the support of the commuting product x shown in the table. The remaining terminals are commuting products: 22, 36 and 58 of them, respectively, including the identity.*

Extending Gern's notation [9, Theorem 2.3.6], we write w_4 and w_6 for his elements of lengths 7 and 15 (viewed inside E_n as in Remark 3.4), and w_7^E, w_8^E for the two new elements of lengths 28 and 50, where w_8^E is the concatenation of the two strings

$$(7534231270123456210321432)(5437210321432543721324357).$$

Type	Terminal b	$\ell(b)$	$x = i(I)$	$\ell(b) - \ell(x)$	Source
E_6	1325213	7	135	4	w_4
E_7	1326213	7	136	4	w_4
E_7	13256213	8	1356	4	$w_4 s_5$
E_7	132543621324356	15	1356	11	w_6
E_7	1325436210321432543621324356	28	1356	24	w_7^E
E_8	1327213	7	137	4	w_4
E_8	13257213	8	1357	4	$w_4 s_5$
E_8	61327213	8	1367	4	$w_4 s_6$
E_8	132543721324357	15	1357	11	w_6
E_8	1325437210321432543721324357	28	1357	24	w_7^E
E_8	w_8^E (displayed above)	50	1357	46	w_8^E

Table 1: The noncommuting terminals of E_6, E_7, E_8 : a reduced word, the length, the unique eligible fully commutative lower endpoint (Corollary 3.2), the gap, and the identification of Remark 3.4. Only the rows of length 15, Gern's D_6 pair, have odd gap.

Corollary 3.2. *Each terminal in Table 1 has the unique eligible fully commutative lower endpoint x displayed there.*

Proof of Corollary 3.2. The induced support graphs have types $D_4, D_4 \sqcup A_1, D_6, E_7$ and E_8 , with independence numbers 3, 4, 4, 4, 4: the matchings (1, 2) in the rows of lengths 7 and 8, (1, 2), (3, 4) in the rows of length 15, (0, 1), (2, 3), (4, 5) in the rows of length 28 and (0, 1), (3, 4), (5, 6), (2, 7) in the row of length 50 bound every independent set by the number of support nodes minus the matching size, and the displayed descent set attains the bound (compare Remark 2.7). If y is eligible, then $\text{supp}(y) \subseteq \text{supp}(b)$ and Lemma 2.4 forces $y = x$; conversely x , a commuting product of left descents of b , is a reduced prefix of b , hence below b and eligible. $\square$

3.2 Exhaustiveness, and the proofs of Theorem 1.1 and Corollary 1.2

All computations use the faithful integral geometric representation [2, Theorem 4.2.7]: right multiplication by s_i replaces the columns $a_j = w(\alpha_j)$ by $a_i \mapsto -a_i$ and $a_j \mapsto a_j + a_i$ for $j \sim i$; signs give descents and (2) tests terminality on both sides. In E_6 and E_7 , breadth-first closure under all generators enumerates the whole group. For E_8 , fix $J \subseteq S$ and write $w = av$ length-additively with $a \in W^J$ (minimal coset representatives) and $v \in W_J$ [2, Proposition 2.4.4 and Corollary 2.4.5]; call w *right-terminal* if no reduced word of w ends in a noncommuting pair.

¹In Bourbaki's labelling of E_n (chain $1-3-4-\dots-n$, node 2 attached to node 4), our node 0 is Bourbaki's node 1, our node j with $1 \leq j \leq n-2$ is Bourbaki's node $j+2$, and our node $n-1$ is Bourbaki's node 2.

Lemma 3.3 (Parabolic pruning). *If $w = av$ is right-terminal, then v is right-terminal in W_J .*

Proof. A reduced word for v ending in adjacent generators, prefixed by a reduced word for a , gives such a word for w , by length additivity. $\square$

The following procedure makes the pruning explicit. Its input is the finite Coxeter diagram and a chain $\emptyset = K_0 \subset K_1 \subset \dots \subset K_m = S$ of standard parabolic subsets; its output is the complete terminal set. Write $\text{RT}_K(u)$ for the right-terminal test (2) using the generators and edges in K .

Parabolic terminal enumeration

Initialize $\mathcal{R}_0 = \{e\}$.

For $i = 1, \dots, m$:

Set $K = K_i$, $J = K_{i-1}$.

Enumerate $C_i = \{a \in W_K : R(a) \cap J = \emptyset\}$.

Set $\mathcal{R}_i = \{av : a \in C_i, v \in \mathcal{R}_{i-1}, \text{RT}_K(av)\}$.

Return $\{w \in \mathcal{R}_m : \text{RT}_S(w^{-1})\}$.

To enumerate C_i , start a queue with e . For each queued a and $s \in K$, strip right J -descents from sa until none remains, and enqueue the resulting element if new. Stripping strictly decreases length and gives the unique minimal representative of saW_J . Left multiplication acts transitively on W_K/W_J , so an exhausted queue contains every coset representative. The implementation also checks $|C_i| = [W_K : W_J]$.

The invariant is that $\mathcal{R}_i$ contains exactly the right-terminal elements of W_{K_i} . Every retained product passes the defining test; conversely, the unique length-additive parabolic factorization $w = av$ of any right-terminal w has $v \in \mathcal{R}_{i-1}$ by Lemma 3.3 and induction. Thus it is tested and retained. Equality is decided in the faithful representation. Each queue is finite because W_K is finite, and the procedure stops after the last parabolic stage; there is no imposed word-length cutoff. The inverse test then imposes left terminality.

The implementation uses the chain $E_8 \supset E_7 \supset E_6 \supset D_5 \supset D_4 \supset A_3 \supset A_2 \supset A_1 \supset \{e\}$, traversed from smallest to largest. The final E_7 parabolic has 576 right-terminals and 240 cosets, their products give 2,160 right-terminals in E_8 , and the inverse test leaves exactly the 64 terminals of Proposition 3.1. With Corollary 3.2, the finite theorem thus needs neither an enumeration of pairs with FC lower endpoint nor a table of Kazhdan–Lusztig polynomials.

Proof of Theorem 1.1. By Lemma 2.2 it suffices to treat terminal b . If b is a commuting product, every $x < b$ is a proper subproduct, so some $s \in L(b) \setminus L(x)$ exists and Lemma 2.1 gives $\mu(x, b) \in \{0, 1\}$. For a noncommuting terminal, Corollary 3.2 and Lemma 2.1 leave one candidate non-cover pair (x, b) per row of Table 1, and parity disposes of all rows except the two of length 15. These are the same pair in a D_6 parabolic subgroup: in E_n , $n = 7, 8$, mapping Gern’s labels $1, \dots, 6$ to $1, n-1, 2, 3, 4, 5$ identifies it with Gern’s $x_6 = (-1, -2, 4, 3, 6, 5)$ and $w_6 = (-1, -6, 3, -4, 5, -2)$ in signed permutation notation [9, Example 1.1.6]. Bruhat order and Kazhdan–Lusztig polynomials of a standard parabolic subgroup agree with those of W , since reduced words of W_J are reduced in W and the Hecke algebra of W_J is a bar-stable subalgebra containing its Kazhdan–Lusztig basis [19, §9.6 and Lemma 9.10(c),(d), with $z = e$]. Gern’s Lemma 4.5.5 [9], a computation with du Cloux’s *Coxeter*, gives $\mu(x_6, w_6) = 1$ (recomputed in Appendix A). Hence every coefficient with terminal upper endpoint lies in $\{0, 1\}$. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 1.2. The irreducible finite simply laced types are A , D and E ; combine Green’s theorem, Gern’s theorem and Theorem 1.1. For a direct product $W = \prod_j W_j$, full commutativity is componentwise and $P_{x,w} = \prod_j P_{x_j, w_j}$: the Hecke algebra and its bar involution factor as tensor products, and the tensor product of the component Kazhdan–Lusztig bases satisfies the defining invariance and triangularity conditions [2, §5.1]. Let $x < w$, let d_j be the component length differences, $d = \sum_j d_j$, and m the number of j with $d_j > 0$. Even d gives $\mu = 0$; for odd d and $m \geq 2$, the bounds $\deg P_{x_j, w_j} \leq (d_j - 1)/2$ for $d_j > 0$ give $\deg P_{x,w} \leq (d - m)/2 < (d - 1)/2$, so $\mu = 0$; for $m = 1$, $\mu(x, w)$ is the coefficient in the single nontrivial component, which lies in $\{0, 1\}$. $\square$

3.3 Relation to the type- D list and further structure

Remark 3.4 (Gern's list plus two). The parabolic subgroup of E_n on $\{1, n-1, 2, \dots, n-2\}$ has type D_{n-1} ; sending Gern's labels $1, 2, j$ ($3 \leq j \leq 7$) to $1, n-1, j-1$ identifies it with Gern's $W(D_{n-1})$, and then the rows of Table 1 of lengths 7, 8 and 15 are Gern's bad elements w_4 , w_4u and w_6 of [9, Theorem 2.3.6], while the E_8 row of length 28 is w_7^E in the parabolic subgroup on $\{0, \dots, 5, 7\}$. Thus the list has the form bu , where $b \in \{w_4, w_6, w_7^E, w_8^E\}$ belongs to the ambient group and u is a commuting product of generators neither in nor adjacent to $\text{supp}(b)$. In E_6 only w_4 occurs; in E_7 the possibilities are w_4, w_6, w_7^E ; in E_8 all four occur. The unique longest terminals in E_7 and E_8 are w_7^E and w_8^E , respectively.

Remark 3.5 (Additional structure). The terminal-structure certificate records reduced layered words and orthogonal-reflection decompositions. The element w_4 is a reflection, w_6 is a product of three orthogonal reflections, and w_7^E and w_8^E are products of four and two pairwise orthogonal reflections, respectively. In the compatible embeddings into E_8 they form a right weak order chain $w_4 < w_6 < w_7^E < w_8^E$. These observations are not needed for Theorem 1.1.

There is also an alternative degree bound. For $b = w_7^E, w_8^E$, $\mu(i(I), b) = 0$ also follows without parity: $J = I \cup \{0\}$ has type $A_2 \times A_1^3$ and $\ell(w_0(J)) = 6$, and $b = u w_0(J) v$ length-additively with lengths $11 + 6 + 11$ and $11 + 6 + 33$ (words in the certificate). A length-increasing simple multiplication decreases the Kazhdan–Lusztig left or right preorder [8, §2], so $b \leq_{LR} w_0(J)$. Consequently Lusztig's a -function satisfies $a(b) \geq a(w_0(J)) = 6$, by [19, Proposition 13.8 and properties P4, P12 of §14.2, proved in Chapter 15]. As $I \subseteq L(b)$, repeated left descent invariance gives $P_{i(I), b} = P_{e, b}$ [2, Proposition 5.1.8 and its left analogue]. In the equal-parameter normalization, $\Delta(b) = \ell(b) - 2 \deg P_{e, b}$; property P1 gives $a(b) \leq \Delta(b)$ [19, §14.1 and §15.2]. Thus $\deg P_{i(I), b} \leq (\ell(b) - 6)/2$, below the degree $(\ell(b) - 5)/2$ of $\mu(i(I), b)$. Likewise $a(w_6) \geq 5$, consistent with $a(w_6) = 5$ [9, Proposition 4.5.1].

4 Infinite families

The finite theorem is now complete. To prove vanishing for the infinite families, the maximum-descent parity criterion handles non-covers, but fully commutative covers would still contribute 1. We first give a geometric argument excluding these covers for the reflections used below. The affine family will use a separate finite catalogue argument.

4.1 Reflections and their covers

The *depth* $\text{dp}(\beta)$ of a positive root β is the least d such that $\beta = s_1 \cdots s_{d-1} \alpha_t$ for simple reflections s_i and a simple root α_t (cf. [2, §4.6]).

Lemma 4.1 (Reflections). *Let (W, S) be simply laced, let β be a positive root and $d = \text{dp}(\beta)$.*

- (i) $\ell(r_\beta) = 2d - 1$, and for every expression $\beta = s_1 \cdots s_{d-1} \alpha_t$ of minimal length the palindromic word $s_1 \cdots s_{d-1} t s_{d-1} \cdots s_1$ is a reduced word for r_β .
- (ii) If $s \in S$ and $(\beta, \alpha_s) < 0$, then $s\beta$ is a positive root of depth $d+1$, $\ell(sr_\beta) = \ell(r_\beta) + 1$ and $\ell(sr_\beta s) = \ell(r_\beta) + 2$. If $(\beta, \alpha_s) > 0$ and $\beta \neq \alpha_s$, then $s\beta$ is a positive root of depth $d - 1$.
- (iii) r_β is fully commutative if and only if β is simple.

Proof. Recall that $\ell(ws) > \ell(w)$ if and only if $w(\alpha_s) > 0$, and that s negates only $\pm \alpha_s$. Let $(\beta, \alpha_s) = -c < 0$. Then $s\beta = \beta + c\alpha_s > 0$; $r_\beta(\alpha_s) = \alpha_s + c\beta > 0$ gives $s \notin R(r_\beta) = L(r_\beta)$, so $\ell(sr_\beta) = \ell(r_\beta) + 1$; and $(sr_\beta)(\alpha_s) = -\alpha_s + c s\beta = c\beta + (c^2 - 1)\alpha_s > 0$ gives $\ell(sr_\beta s) = \ell(r_\beta) + 2$. As $sr_\beta s = r_{s\beta}$, this shows $\ell(r_{s\beta}) = \ell(r_\beta) + 2$ when $(\beta, \alpha_s) < 0$ and, applied to $s\beta$, $\ell(r_{s\beta}) = \ell(r_\beta) - 2$ when $(\beta, \alpha_s) > 0$, $\beta \neq \alpha_s$. Now $\ell(r_\beta) = 2 \text{dp}(\beta) - 1$ by induction on the odd number $\ell(r_\beta)$ (trivial for $\ell(r_\beta) = 1$): if $\ell(r_\beta) \geq 3$, some s has $(\beta, \alpha_s) > 0$, $\beta \neq \alpha_s$ (as $(\beta, \beta) = 2$, $\beta \geq 0$), so $\beta' = s\beta > 0$ has $\ell(r_{\beta'}) = \ell(r_\beta) - 2 = 2 \text{dp}(\beta') - 1$ and $\text{dp}(\beta) \leq \text{dp}(\beta') + 1$ gives $2 \text{dp}(\beta) - 1 \leq \ell(r_\beta)$, while the palindromic word gives $\ell(r_\beta) \leq 2d - 1$. This proves (i); (ii) follows from (i) and the two length formulas. For (iii), if $d \geq 2$ the reduced word of (i) contains $s_{d-1} t s_{d-1}$, which equals t unless $m(s_{d-1}, t) = 3$; so it is a braid factor and $r_\beta \notin W_{\text{FC}}$ [21, Proposition 2.1]. $\square$

Lemma 4.2 (Covers of terminal reflections). *Let $n \geq 6$, $W = W(E_n)$, and let $b = r_\beta$ for a positive root β with at least three nonzero coordinates. Suppose $L(b) = R(b) = I$, where I is a maximum independent set of the subgraph induced by $\text{supp}(b)$ and $|I|$ is odd. Then no Bruhat cover of b is fully commutative. Consequently $\mu(x, b) = 0$ for every fully commutative x .*

Proof. Let $x < b$ with $\ell(x) = \ell(b) - 1$. If $I \subseteq L(x) \cap R(x)$ and $x \in W_{\text{FC}}$, then $\text{supp}(x) \subseteq \text{supp}(b)$ and Lemma 2.4 gives $x = i(I)$ of odd length $|I|$, impossible as $\ell(b)$ is odd. Otherwise some $s \in I$ has $s \notin L(x)$ (or, symmetrically, $s \notin R(x)$); the lifting property [2, Proposition 2.2.7] gives $x \leq sb$, hence $x = sb = (bs)^{-1}$ by length and involutivity, and it suffices to show $bs \notin W_{\text{FC}}$. Put $m = (\alpha_s, \beta)$; $s \in R(b)$ gives $b(\alpha_s) = \alpha_s - m\beta < 0$, so $m \geq 1$, and $s\beta = \beta - m\alpha_s$ is a positive non-simple root, its coordinates off s being those of β . Since $sbs = r_{s\beta}$ and $(\alpha_s, s\beta) = -m < 0$, Lemma 4.1(ii) gives $\ell(sr_{s\beta}) = \ell(r_{s\beta}) + 1$, so s followed by the palindromic word of Lemma 4.1(i) for $r_{s\beta}$ is a reduced word for bs containing a braid factor; hence $bs \notin W_{\text{FC}}$. Non-covers are handled by Proposition 2.5, since $\ell(b)$ and $|I|$ are odd. $\square$

4.2 The rank-uniform construction

The construction begins with the hypotheses of Lemma 4.2. We seek a positive real root β with full support such that the positive simple-root pairings occur on a maximum independent set I of odd size. Indeed, writing $m_j = (\alpha_j, \beta)$ gives

$$r_\beta(\alpha_j) = \alpha_j - m_j\beta.$$

Since β has full support, this root is negative precisely when $m_j > 0$. Thus the signs of the m_j prescribe the descent set. For an edge $s \sim t$ incident to I , the inequality $m_s + m_t \leq 0$ also gives

$$r_\beta(\alpha_s + \alpha_t) = \alpha_s + \alpha_t - (m_s + m_t)\beta > 0,$$

which is the terminal test. The task is therefore to construct real roots whose pairings have these signs and edge inequalities.

The seed below has alternating pairings along the long arm. We then iterate a product of two reflections in an embedded affine subsystem. This preserves real-root membership and produces an explicit quadratic orbit on which the same inequalities can be checked for every parameter. The reality of the seed is proved separately: norm 2 alone would not establish it in an indefinite root system.

Fix an integer $r \geq 3$, put $n = 4r + 1$, and use the E_n numbering of Section 1, so node $4r$ is attached to node 2. Define β_r by its coordinates $(\beta_r)_0 = r - 1$, $(\beta_r)_1 = r$, $(\beta_r)_2 = 2r - 1$, $(\beta_r)_{4r} = r$ and $(\beta_r)_j = 2r - \lfloor j/2 \rfloor$ for $3 \leq j \leq 4r - 1$, where $(v)_j$ denotes the coefficient of α_j in v ; so the long-arm coordinates are $2r - 1, 2r - 2, 2r - 2, \dots, 1, 1$. Put $I_r = \{0, 3, 5, \dots, 4r - 1, 4r\}$ and $a = 2r - 4$. On the embedded affine E_8 subdiagram $\{0, \dots, 7, 4r\}$ set $(\delta_0, \dots, \delta_7) = (2, 4, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1)$, $\delta_{4r} = 3$, $(\gamma_0, \dots, \gamma_7) = (1, 2, 3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 0)$, $\gamma_{4r} = 1$, with all other coordinates zero. Set $T = r_\gamma r_{\gamma+\delta}$ and, for $k \geq 0$,

$$\beta_{r,k} = \beta_r - ak\gamma + (ak^2 + rk)\delta, \quad b_{r,k} = r_{\beta_{r,k}}. \quad (3)$$

Lemma 4.3. *For every $r \geq 3$, β_r is a real root of E_{4r+1} .*

Proof. Deleting node 0 leaves finite type D_{4r} ; realize its simple roots in an orthonormal basis $e_1, \dots, e_{4r}$ as $\alpha_1 = e_1 + e_2$, $\alpha_{4r} = e_2 - e_1$, $\alpha_j = e_{j+1} - e_j$ ($2 \leq j \leq 4r - 1$), take z orthogonal to them with $(z, z) = 2 - r$, and put $\alpha_0 = z - \frac{1}{2} \sum_i e_i$; these vectors have the Cartan inner products of E_{4r+1} and form a basis, the Cartan determinant $9 - n$ being nonzero. Then $\beta_r = (r - 1)z + \sum_i c_i e_i$ with $c_i = -(r - 1)/2$ for odd and $(3 - r)/2$ for even i , and $(\beta_r, \alpha_0) = r - 2$ gives $s_0\beta_r = F\alpha_0$, where F flips the $2r$ even coordinates. As $F = \prod_{j=1}^r r_{e_{4j-2}-e_{4j}} r_{e_{4j-2}+e_{4j}} \in W(D_{4r})$ [9, Example 1.1.6], $\beta_r = s_0 F \alpha_0$ is a real root. $\square$

Lemma 4.4. *Suppose γ and $\gamma + \delta$ are real roots with $(\gamma, \gamma) = 2$ and $(\gamma, \delta) = (\delta, \delta) = 0$, and let $T = r_\gamma r_{\gamma+\delta}$. Then*

$$(T - 1)\rho = (\rho, \delta)\gamma - ((\rho, \gamma) + (\rho, \delta))\delta, \quad (T - 1)^3 = 0,$$

and if $(\beta, \delta) = -a$ and $(\beta, \gamma) = -c$, then

$$T^k \beta = \beta - ak\gamma + (ak^2 + ck)\delta \quad (k \geq 0). \quad (4)$$

Proof. Compose the two reflection formulas. With $N = T - 1$, $N\delta = 0$ and $N\gamma = -2\delta$ give $N^3 = 0$, and $N\beta = -a\gamma + (a + c)\delta$, $N^2\beta = 2a\delta$; expand $(1 + N)^k$ binomially. The lemma holds on the whole ambient root space, where δ need not be in the radical. $\square$

Lemma 4.5. *For all $r \geq 3$ and $k \geq 0$, $\beta_{r,k} = T^k \beta_r$ is a real root with every coordinate strictly positive. Its reflection $b_{r,k}$ is terminal and has both descent sets equal to I_r .*

Proof. The vector γ is a root of the finite E_8 parabolic subsystem obtained by omitting node 7, and $\gamma + \delta$ is an affine real root (explicit lowering sequences are given in Appendix A.3). As $(\beta_r, \gamma) = -r$ and $(\beta_r, \delta) = -a$, (4) gives $T^k \beta_r = \beta_{r,k}$, a real root, and the binomial increments $(a + r)\delta - a\gamma$ and $2a\delta$ are coordinatewise nonnegative for $r \geq 3$, so every coordinate of $\beta_{r,k}$ is strictly positive. The pairings $m_j = (\alpha_j, \beta_{r,k})$ are

$$\begin{aligned} m_0 &= r - 2, & m_1 &= 2 - r, & m_2 &= -1 - ak, & m_8 &= -1 - ak^2 - rk, & m_{4r} &= 1 + ak, \\ m_j &= (-1)^{j+1}(1 + ak) \quad (3 \leq j \leq 7), & m_j &= (-1)^{j+1} \quad (9 \leq j \leq 4r - 1), \end{aligned}$$

positive exactly on I_r . Since $\beta_{r,k} > 0$, $b_{r,k}(\alpha_j) = \alpha_j - m_j \beta_{r,k}$ is negative exactly when $m_j > 0$, so $R(b_{r,k}) = I_r = L(b_{r,k})$ by involutivity. For every edge $s \sim t$ with $s \in I_r$ the sum $m_s + m_t$ is nonpositive (at $7 - 8$ it is $-ak(k - 1) - rk$, at $8 - 9$ it is $-ak^2 - rk$, elsewhere by inspection), so $b_{r,k}(\alpha_s + \alpha_t) = \alpha_s + \alpha_t - (m_s + m_t)\beta_{r,k} > 0$, which is (2); the left test follows by involutivity. $\square$

For a concrete example, take $r = 3$, so $n = 13$ and the branch is node 12. At $k = 0$ the seed and its simple-root pairings are

$$\begin{aligned} \beta_{3,0} &= (2, 3, 5, 5, 4, 4, 3, 3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 3), \\ (m_0, \dots, m_{12}) &= (1, -1, -1, 1, -1, 1, -1, 1, -1, 1, -1, 1, 1). \end{aligned}$$

For example, the branching node gives $m_2 = 2 \cdot 5 - 3 - 5 - 3 = -1$, while $m_{12} = 2 \cdot 3 - 5 = 1$. The positive entries occur on $I_3 = \{0, 3, 5, 7, 9, 11, 12\}$, and every edge incident to I_3 has pairing sum zero. Along the orbit, the two exceptional sums become $m_7 + m_8 = -2k(k - 1) - 3k$ and $m_8 + m_9 = -2k^2 - 3k$. They remain nonpositive for every integer $k \geq 0$, illustrating why the quadratic perturbation preserves terminality.

Proof of Theorem 1.3. The set I_r is independent of size $2r + 1$, and the matching $(0, 1), (2, 4r), (3, 4), (5, 6), \dots, (4r - 3, 4r - 2)$ with $2r$ edges leaves one vertex unmatched, so I_r is a maximum independent set of E_{4r+1} (compare Remark 2.7). By Lemma 4.5, $b_{r,k}$ is a terminal reflection with $L = R = I_r$, $|I_r|$ is odd, and $\beta_{r,k}$ has $4r + 1 \geq 3$ nonzero coordinates, so Lemma 4.2 gives $\mu(x, b_{r,k}) = 0$ for every fully commutative x , and $b_{r,k} \notin W_{FC}$ by Lemma 4.1(iii). Since $m_0 = r - 2 > 0$ and $\beta_{r,k}$ is positive in every coordinate, column 0 of $b_{r,k}$ changes every coordinate row, whereas omitting a generator would leave its row unchanged; so $b_{r,k}$ has full support. Distinct positive roots give distinct reflections, and $(\beta_{r,k})_0 = r - 1 + 4k + (4r - 8)k^2$ gives distinctness. $\square$

Remark 4.6. At $r = 3$ one has $\ell(b_{3,0}) = 75$, while the maximum lengths of fully commutative elements of $E_{10}, \dots, E_{13}$ are 55, 66, 78 and 92 (Appendix A), so a length-based exclusion of fully commutative covers already fails in rank 13; the lengths $\ell(b_{r,k}) = 8r^2 + 3 + 116k$ hold for every pair in the certificate ($r \leq 8$, $k \leq 3$; the supplement's optional extended run adds $r = 9, 10, 12$) but are not needed. The restriction $r \geq 3$ is structural: at $r = 2$, $\beta_2 = \delta - \gamma$, $(\alpha_0, \beta_2) = 0$, and the descent set has even size 4.

4.3 The affine family

Use E_9 numbering: chain $0-1-\dots-7$ with node 8 attached to 2; the affine node is 7. Put

$$\delta' = (2, 4, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1, 3), \quad \gamma' = (1, 1, 1, 1, 1, 0, 0, 0, 0), \quad I' = \{1, 3, 5, 7, 8\},$$

and

$$c_0 = 312875645234123012856745231,$$

a reduced word for an involution. Let $T' = r_{\gamma'} r_{\gamma' + \delta'}$, so that $T'(\alpha) = \alpha - (\alpha, \gamma')\delta'$, and define $c_k = T'^k c_0 T'^{-k}$ for $k \geq 0$.

Theorem 4.7 (Explicit affine family). *Every c_k is a full-support terminal element of $W(\tilde{E}_8)$ that is not fully commutative, with*

$$L(c_k) = R(c_k) = I', \quad \ell(c_k) = 27 + 92k.$$

For every fully commutative $x \in W(\tilde{E}_8)$ and every $k \geq 0$, $\mu(x, c_k) = 0$.

Proof. The vector δ' is the null root and γ' is a root of the finite E_8 parabolic subsystem obtained by omitting node 7. Multiplying out the displayed word gives $c_0^2 = 1$. The columns $c_0(\alpha_j)$ of the matrix of c_0 recorded in the affine certificate (Appendix A; the certificate stores the matrix by rows) are negative precisely at the indices in I' , and for every edge incident to I' the sum of the two columns is a positive root; by (2) and involutivity, c_0 is terminal on both sides. Put $d = (2, -1, 1, -1, 1, -1, 1, -1)$. Then $(\alpha_j, \gamma' - c_0\gamma') = d_j$, and conjugation gives

$$c_k(\alpha_j) = c_0(\alpha_j) + kd_j\delta'. \quad (5)$$

As d is negative on I' and positive off I' , like the base columns, both descent sets stay I' ; on every edge $s \sim t$ with $s \in I'$ one has $d_s + d_t \geq 0$, so (5) preserves positivity of $c_k(\alpha_s + \alpha_t)$, and c_k is terminal. Full support holds at $k = 0$ by the displayed word and at $k \geq 1$ because each descent column is strictly negative in every coordinate, whereas omitting a generator would leave its row unchanged. The c_k are pairwise distinct by (5), since every $d_j \neq 0$.

For the length, use the affine-root realization [15, §§4.1–4.3 and §6.5] and count positive roots sent negative [2, Proposition 4.4.4]: for each of the 240 finite roots η write $c_0\eta = \eta' + h\delta'$, let $\epsilon(\eta)$ be 0 for positive and 1 for negative η ; the positive affine roots $\eta + m\delta'$, $m \geq \epsilon(\eta)$, contribute $\max(0, A_\eta + kB_\eta)$ to $\ell(c_k)$, where $A_\eta = \epsilon(\eta') - h - \epsilon(\eta)$ and $B_\eta = -\sum_j \eta_j d_j$. The nonzero contributions, grouped by (A_η, B_η) , are

(A, B)	$(0, 1)$	$(0, 2)$	$(1, 0)$	$(1, 1)$	$(1, 2)$
Multiplicity	44	8	1	20	6

and the remaining 161 vanish for all $k \geq 0$; the sum is $27 + 92k$.

By Remark 2.7, I' is a maximum independent set, of size 5, and $\ell(c_k)$ is odd, so Proposition 2.5 gives $\mu(x, c_k) = 0$ for every fully commutative non-cover x . Let x be a fully commutative cover of c_k . If $I' \subseteq L(x) \cap R(x)$, then Lemma 2.4 gives $x = i(I')$ of length $5 < \ell(c_k) - 1$. Otherwise, by the lifting property [2, Proposition 2.2.7], $x = sc_k$ or $x = c_k s$ for some $s \in I'$, as in the proof of Lemma 4.2. For $k \geq 1$ these elements have length $26 + 92k \geq 118$, exceeding the maximum length 44 of a fully commutative element of $\tilde{E}_8$ (complete catalogue of 44,199 elements, Appendix A, in agreement with [1, §5.2]). For $k = 0$, every cover arises by deleting one letter from the displayed reduced word, by the strong exchange condition [2, Theorem 1.4.3]; the deletions give exactly 21 distinct elements of length 26, none fully commutative (Appendix A). Hence $\mu(x, c_k) = 0$ for every fully commutative x . Finally, $c_k \notin W_{\text{FC}}$, since otherwise Lemma 2.4 would force $c_k = i(I')$. (Lemma 4.2 does not apply directly: c_0 is not a reflection.) $\square$

4.4 The E_{10} family

The first indefinite rank E_{10} lies outside the sequence E_{4r+1} . Embed the affine subdiagram on $\{0, \dots, 7, 9\}$ and take $\hat{\delta} = (2, 4, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1, 0, 3)$, $\hat{\gamma} = (1, 2, 3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 0, 0, 1)$ (so $\hat{\gamma}$ differs from γ' of Section 4.3), $\hat{\beta}_0 = (3, 7, 10, 9, 7, 6, 4, 3, 1, 6)$, $\hat{I} = \{1, 3, 5, 7, 9\}$, $\hat{T} = r_{\hat{\gamma}} r_{\hat{\gamma} + \hat{\delta}}$, and for $k \geq 0$

$$\hat{\beta}_k = \hat{\beta}_0 - k\hat{\gamma} + (k^2 + 3k)\hat{\delta}, \quad \hat{b}_k = r_{\hat{\beta}_k}. \quad (6)$$

Proposition 4.8. *The reflections $\hat{b}_k$, $k \geq 0$, are pairwise distinct full-support terminal elements of $W(E_{10})$ that are not fully commutative, with $L(\hat{b}_k) = R(\hat{b}_k) = \hat{I}$. For every fully commutative x and every $k \geq 0$, $\mu(x, \hat{b}_k) = 0$.*

Proof. The explicit lowering sequence in Appendix A.3 reduces $\hat{\beta}_0$ to α_9 ; $\hat{\gamma}$, $\hat{\gamma} + \hat{\delta}$ are real roots of the embedded affine subsystem; and $(\hat{\beta}_0, \hat{\gamma}) = -3$, $(\hat{\beta}_0, \hat{\delta}) = -1$, so Lemma 4.4 gives $\hat{\beta}_k = \hat{T}^k \hat{\beta}_0$ with nonnegative increments $4\hat{\delta} - \hat{\gamma}$, $2\hat{\delta}$, whence $\hat{\beta}_k > 0$ in every coordinate. The pairings

$$((\alpha_j, \hat{\beta}_k))_{j=0}^9 = (-1, 1, -2 - k, 1 + k, -1 - k, 1 + k, -1 - k, 1 + k, -1 - k^2 - 3k, 2 + k)$$

are positive exactly on $\hat{I}$ with nonpositive sums over adjacent entries, giving both descent sets and terminality by (2); $(\alpha_1, \hat{\beta}_k) = 1$ gives full support (column 1 changes every row) and $(\hat{\beta}_k)_0 = 2k^2 + 5k + 3$ distinctness. $\hat{I}$ is a maximum independent set of odd size 5 (Remark 2.7) and $\hat{\beta}_k$ has ten nonzero coordinates, so Lemma 4.2 gives $\mu(x, \hat{\beta}_k) = 0$ for every fully commutative x , and $\hat{\beta}_k \notin W_{\text{FC}}$ by Lemma 4.1(iii). $\square$

Standard parabolic embeddings transport the $\tilde{E}_8$ and E_{10} families to larger E_n , with the supports of the smaller parabolic subgroups.

5 Complements and open problems

5.1 Necessity of the fully commutative hypothesis

The complete E_6 calculation gives $\max \mu(x, w) = 10$ (Appendix A). One pair attaining this maximum is

$$x = 01254012010, \quad w = 123012523412301251234012.$$

Here $\ell(x) = 11$, x is not FC, and w has full support and length 24. The polynomial is

$$P_{x,w} = 1 + 13q + 59q^2 + 121q^3 + 125q^4 + 61q^5 + 10q^6.$$

Exactly 1,386 pairs have $\mu \geq 2$ (400, 556, 310, 108, 4 and 8 pairs with $\mu = 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 10$), all with non-FC lower endpoint, while all 6,431 nonzero values with fully commutative lower endpoint equal 1, a brute-force confirmation of Theorem 1.1 for E_6 (by parabolic inclusion, $\mu \geq 10$ occurs in E_7 and E_8 as well). Full commutativity of the upper endpoint alone does not suffice either: $x = 5343010$ (not FC) and $w = 0125342312501234$ (FC, $\ell = 16$) have

$$P_{x,w} = 1 + 8q + 22q^2 + 20q^3 + 5q^4, \quad \mu(x, w) = 5.$$

5.2 The bound fails in affine type

In $\tilde{D}_4$, with x the product of the four leaves and c the centre, $w = xcx$ has $P_{x,w} = 1 + 3q + 2q^2$ and $\mu(x, w) = 2$. The upper endpoint is a boolean reflection: commuting the leaves rewrites it as a palindrome whose first half and centre use distinct generators. Thus Mongelli's formula for boolean elements in tree Coxeter groups [20, Corollary 3] applies and gives $f_4(q) = 1 + 3q + 2q^2$; Corollary 2 of the same source also gives $\mu(x, w) = 2$ directly. The value is recomputed in Appendix A. Hence Corollary 1.2 is sharp within simply laced type, and the universal form of Green's question has a negative answer. Vanishing of μ does not mean $P = 1$: in finite D_4 , with x the product of the three leaves, $b = xcx$ has maximum common commuting descents and even gap 4, so $\mu(x, b) = 0$, but $P_{x,b} = 1 + 2q$ [20, Corollary 3] (the same construction with three leaves gives f_3).

5.3 Terminals in affine E_8 beyond the family

The reflection

$$w = r_\beta = 875634523412301282341230128567453, \quad \beta = (1, 2, 3, 3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 2),$$

of length 33 is a full-support terminal with $L(w) = R(w) = \{3, 5, 7, 8\}$, which is not a maximum independent set, so Proposition 2.5 does not apply. It has exactly five eligible fully commutative lower endpoints, all with $\deg P_{x,w} = 13$:

x	8753	87530	87531	875301	875310
gap $\ell(w) - \ell(x)$	29	28	28	27	27
$\mu(x, w)$	0	0	0	1	1

The right extensions ws_0 and ws_1 of length 34 are terminal involutions with $L = R = \{0, 3, 5, 7, 8\}$, respectively $\{1, 3, 5, 7, 8\}$, each a maximum independent set, each with a unique eligible fully commutative lower endpoint (87530, respectively 87531, gap 29, $\deg P = 14$) and $\mu = 1$, so these two pairs satisfy every hypothesis of

Proposition 2.5 except parity. All values found lie in $\{0, 1\}$. The polynomials and the sizes of the lower ideals and quotients are recorded in the certificate (Appendix A); the computation runs the ordinary Kazhdan–Lusztig recursion [2, Theorem 5.1.7], identifying lower endpoints in the same right coset of $W_{R(w)}$: for fixed w , $P_{x,w} = P_{xs,w}$ for $s \in R(w)$ [2, Proposition 5.1.8]. These are ordinary polynomials computed using coset representatives, not parabolic Kazhdan–Lusztig polynomials.

5.4 Open problems

1. Is $\mu(x, w) \in \{0, 1\}$ for every fully commutative x and every $w \in W(\tilde{E}_8)$? All values computed here, including those of Section 5.3, lie in $\{0, 1\}$.
2. Let Λ be the translation subgroup of $W(\tilde{E}_8) = W(E_9)$. Classify the terminal elements modulo the relation $b \sim c$ if $c = bbt^{-1}$ for some $t \in \Lambda$. For indefinite E_n , fix the embedded affine subgroup on $\{0, \dots, 7, n-1\}$ and ask the same question using its translation subgroup. Here the relation is restricted to terminal endpoints; translation conjugation need not preserve terminality in general.
3. Determine μ for the translated length-33 reflection family $r_{\beta+k\delta'}$, $k \geq 1$, of Section 5.3.
4. Determine the bound in F_4 , H_3 and H_4 , the finite irreducible types not treated by the results cited here.
5. Give an effective description of all noncommuting terminals of E_n for $n \geq 9$. The affine family and its standard parabolic embeddings show that no finite list exists.

Use of AI tools

Large language models from OpenAI and Anthropic assisted with literature searches, constructions, proof drafts, implementation, and internal checks. The author directed the work and takes responsibility for the manuscript. The reproducible computations and their dependencies are described in Appendix A; AI-generated review notes are not peer review. A concise account of the workflow is kept in `PROVENANCE.md` in the repository.

A Computational certificates

A.1 Proof inputs and additional checks

The finite theorem uses the exhaustive terminal classification, the word and descent data of Table 1, and the D_6 value

$$P_{x_6, w_6} = 1 + 6q + 11q^2 + 6q^3 + q^4 + q^5.$$

The classification algorithm and its completeness argument are in Section 3.2. Full E_6 and E_7 enumerations in two representations agree with the recursive classification. In E_8 a separate D_7 -parabolic enumeration gives the same terminal list, and the recursive engine also agrees along four parabolic chains. The D_6 value is checked through all 24,245 dependency records of a saved recurrence certificate and recomputed by separate programs, including directly in the ambient E_7 and E_8 groups.

For the uniform and E_{10} families, the parameter arguments are the symbolic proofs of Section 4. Their finite real-root witnesses are printed in Appendix A.3. The affine family additionally uses the matrix and inversion data of c_0 , the complete FC catalogue with maximum length 44, and the exclusion of all 21 base covers. The catalogue criterion is proved below. Table 2 identifies the principal programs; the supplement README gives the full command and certificate inventory.

The further computations concern the structure in Remarks 3.4–3.5, the results of Section 5, and checks beyond what the proofs require. These include the finite FC counts (agreeing with [22, Appendix, Table 1])

Proof input	Principal commands
Finite terminal lists	<code>terminals-recursive</code> , <code>e8-d7</code> , <code>enumerate-bad</code> , <code>matrix-search</code>
Printed finite words and descents	<code>finite-descents</code> , <code>verify-outputs</code> , <code>verify-e8</code>
D_6 coefficient	<code>d6-certificate</code> , <code>d8-germ-kl</code> , <code>d6-ambient</code>
Uniform root identities	<code>uniform-verify</code>
Affine matrix and inversions	<code>affine-proof</code>
Affine FC catalogue and covers	<code>fc-catalogue</code> , <code>affine-fc-covers</code>
E_{10} root identities	<code>e10-all-k</code>

Table 2: Principal proof computations. Each name is a command under `supplement/cmd/`. Additional programs check alternative implementations and the supplementary results.

and [1, §5.1]), FC maxima in E_{10} – E_{13} , and finite-rank checks of the uniform identities. The D_8 calculation provides a further check against Gern’s thesis:

$$P_{x_8^D, w_8^D} = P_{e, w_8^D} = 1 + 12q + 59q^2 + 154q^3 + 233q^4 + 221q^5 \\ + 147q^6 + 70q^7 + 20q^8 + 2q^9.$$

Here $x_8^D = s_1 s_2 s_4 s_6 s_8$ and $w_8^D = (1, -8, 3, -6, 5, -4, 7, -2)$ in Gern’s signed-permutation convention. This type- D_8 element is distinct from the exceptional terminal w_8^E of Table 1.

A.2 Why the fully commutative catalogue is exhaustive

The catalogue is constructed by increasing length, starting with the identity. The following criterion gives both the acceptance rule and the reason that discarding a candidate cannot lose an FC element.

Lemma A.1 (Catalogue criterion). *In a simply laced Coxeter system, a nonidentity element w is fully commutative if and only if $R(w)$ is a commuting set and ws is fully commutative for every $s \in R(w)$.*

Proof. If w is FC, every reduced prefix is FC and $R(w)$ is commuting, so both conditions follow. Conversely, suppose w is not FC and choose a reduced word containing a braid sts , $m(s, t) = 3$. If this occurrence is followed by another letter, deleting the last letter gives a reduced word with the same braid for some wu , $u \in R(w)$; thus wu is not FC. If the occurrence is at the end, the braid relation replaces the suffix sts by tst , putting both s and t in $R(w)$. In either case one of the two conditions fails. $\square$

For every retained element v of length d , the program forms vs for each right ascent s . A candidate w of length $d + 1$ is retained exactly when its right descents commute and all wt , $t \in R(w)$, are in the completed length- d layer. Root matrices identify duplicate elements. Induction using Lemma A.1 proves that each layer contains exactly the FC elements of that length. If a layer has no accepted extensions, no longer FC element exists, since every reduced prefix of an FC element is FC. Thus termination is checked by closure, not imposed by a length cutoff.

In E_9 this procedure gives 44,199 elements, with maximum length 44. A separate verifier checks the catalogue and closure, and tests the elements obtained by single-letter deletions from the reduced word for c_0 . Exactly 21 distinct deletions have length 26; these are all Bruhat covers by strong exchange, and none belongs to the FC catalogue. This is the finite computational input to Theorem 4.7.

A.3 Explicit real-root witnesses

The finite witnesses used in Section 4 can be checked directly from the simple-reflection rule. If $v = (v_j)$, then s_i changes only coordinate i , replacing it by

$$(s_i v)_i = -v_i + \sum_{j \sim i} v_j.$$

A sequence $i_1 \cdots i_m$ below means *apply s_{i_1} first*, then s_{i_2} , and so on; its action is $s_{i_m} \cdots s_{i_1}$. This is the order of application, rather than the product-word convention of Table 1. Parenthesized strings are concatenated.

For the affine subdiagram on $\{0, \dots, 7, p\}$, with branch p at node 2, set

$$\begin{aligned}\sigma &= 210432165432, \\ \tau &= (210432165432)(p210321432543654765)(p210321432).\end{aligned}$$

Applied to γ and $\gamma + \delta$, respectively, these sequences end at α_p . Take $p = 4r$ for the uniform construction and $p = 9$ for the hatted roots of E_{10} . All intermediate vectors are positive, and each step decreases height. For example, the first step on $\gamma = (1, 2, 3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 0, 1)$ in coordinates $0, \dots, 7, p$ changes coordinate 2 from 3 to $-3 + 2 + 2 + 1 = 2$.

For β_0 in E_{10} , the sequence

$$(135476592103214325678921032)(14325436547659210321432)$$

ends at α_9 , again through positive vectors of decreasing height. These explicit identities establish real-root membership, independently of the norm calculation. The supplement regenerates and checks the same witnesses.

A.4 Reproduction and implementation independence

All arithmetic in the supplement is exact. Separate implementations provide checks with different representations. The flat and recursive terminal engines share the library `internal/parabolic`. The commands `affine-proof` and `affine-fc-covers` share `internal/affine`. The saved D_6 recurrence checker shares group arithmetic with its generator, so it is a consistency check. The `d8-germ-kl` and `d6-ambient` recomputations use separate code. The supplement README records the remaining dependencies.

The repository <https://github.com/tygern/kl> contains the source, inputs, certificates and archive builder. From its root, run

```
go run -C supplement ./cmd/package
```

to build an archive containing the current manuscript snapshot and a SHA-256 manifest. The archive is `supplement/dist/exceptional-leading-proof.zip`. Extract it, enter the directory `exceptional-leading-proof`, and run

```
go run ./cmd/proofs -full
```

The runner builds the programs, recomputes the results in an isolated working directory, compares regenerated certificates with the supplied snapshots, and checks a stable summary. Go 1.22 or later suffices; no external packages are required. Without `-full`, the runner still recomputes the classifications but uses saved full-group E_6/E_7 snapshots for comparison and omits the heavier cross-checks. Release `v0.5.1` contains this manuscript, its study companion and the citation audit; `v0.5.0` preserves the preceding exposition revision. Manifests identify the exact sources used in each run and provide integrity checks, not proof by themselves.

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